

LAND WARS
A protester uproots a survey stone during a standoff with K-Rail officials in Chottanikara, Ernakulam district

semi high-speed trains."

Kerala's public debt, too, stands at Rs 3.36 lakh crore and the state government is yet to find additional revenues to reduce the fiscal deficit. Congress leader of the Opposition V.D. Satheesan spells it out: "We support the development of the state, but K-Rail cannot ensure it, and the government has not fully explored all the alternatives. Spending Rs 70,000 crore is not a viable option...."

WHERE ARE THE RIDERS?

According to the detailed project report (DPR) of K-Rail done by French firm Systra, over 158,271 people travel from the north and south of the state in cars, taxis, etc. daily and 88,442 by bus. Another 91,975 persons take the train to cover the distance. Passengers using cars now spend Rs 10 per km while the projected SilverLine charges will be around Rs 2.75 per km (on par with current first-class train fares).

The feasibility report predicts about 82,000 riders a day by 2028. Here, too, there has been some controversy, with critics pointing out that the preliminary study had put rider strength at around 45,000. The final report also took a U-turn, they say, on the broad gauge issue. The K-Rail will now run on standard gauge, which will not align with existing rail systems. Project officials counter that saying 200 kmph trains need standard gauge, and point to Delhi Metro and others, saying this is no anomaly.

THE FEASIBILITY REPORT PREDICTS 82,000 RIDERS DAILY BY 2028, BUT CRITICS SAY THE PRELIMINARY STUDY HAD ESTIMATED ONLY HALF THE NUMBERS

Then there are the green concerns. In a land where even Coca Cola and other big corporates have had to shut shop and leave, green activists and scientists have naturally been at the forefront of the protests. They allege that K-Rail will divide Kerala into two, blocking the natural flow of rivers that could prove to be an ecological disaster in the future, especially with the inclement weather patterns in the state. The state has 44 rivers and a large number of water channels and streams. KSSP's Menon says, "K-Rail will have an adverse impact on the Western Ghats, not to mention our water sources, as the project will need huge amounts of granite and loose soil for construction work."

But government officials say there is no scientific evidence to support such claims and point to the proposed elevated rail lines in many places to say the rivers are safe. The government has also mapped the flooded areas in the state after the three consecutive floods (2018-20). The CPI(M)'s official stand is that all this is the work of "professional mischief-mongers". "We honour the concerns of environmentalists and are committed to addressing ecological concerns. But we will not yield to misinformation campaigns or sponsored media ones against the project," CPI(M) state secretary Kodiyeri Balakrishnan told INDIA TODAY.

A PEOPLE'S PROJECT?

The state government has demarcated Rs 13,362 crore for land acquisition (1,398 hectares in all). Though the protests are still raging, especially in central Travancore and north Kerala, sources say a lot of the affected people, especially those in the BPL category and others living close to existing rail lines (in many sections, K-Rail will run adjacent to them) are relatively happy with the compensation packages announced. Packages such as Rs 4.6 lakh for the loss of a home apart from entitled compensation, five cents of land and Rs 10 lakh for the poor, etc. have been received well.

This was more than evident when Union minister V. Muraleedharan of the BJP, out on a Pratirodha Yatra in support of the anti-SilverLine protests, visited an affected village in Kazhakuttom near capital Thiruvananthapuram. In at least some houses, the BJP members were met by mothers who told the TV cameras that they fully supported K-Rail even as the embarrassed minister tried to convince them otherwise. The BJP delegation probably erred in choosing 'party houses' for the media event, but it's still an indication of the massive support Pinarayi enjoys among the common people. K-Rail is a very ambitious project and, as he wishes, it could turn out be his legacy. Or not. ■